

# CHATGPT FIELD GUIDE

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4-page demo • September 2026

## 01 — WHAT CHATGPT ACTUALLY IS

ChatGPT began as a conversational AI research preview on November 30, 2022. The original experience was intentionally simple: a user typed a request and the system responded conversationally. The model was trained with reinforcement learning from human feedback, and OpenAI emphasized follow-up questions, acknowledging mistakes and refusing inappropriate requests.

Today, ChatGPT is better understood as a product ecosystem rather than a single model. The model is the intelligence engine; tools extend what it can do; context tells it what matters; and workflows turn individual capabilities into repeatable work.

### THE FOUR-LAYER MODEL

- Model — the underlying AI that understands, reasons and generates.
- Tools — web search, code execution, file analysis, image generation, computer use and other capabilities.
- Context — your instructions, files, project material, connected sources and relevant memory where enabled.
- Workflow — a sequence such as research → analysis → drafting → verification → delivery.

The important mindset shift is this: do not ask only, “What can ChatGPT tell me?” Ask, “What outcome can I delegate, what context does it need, which tools should it use, and how will I verify the result?”

## 02 — FROM RESEARCH LAB TO MASS-MARKET AI

OpenAI was founded in 2015 as a nonprofit with a mission centered on ensuring that artificial general intelligence benefits all of humanity. The organization later created a for-profit subsidiary to scale research and deployment. The ChatGPT story is therefore part of a longer progression in large-scale generative AI.

The broad path was: generative pretraining → larger models → instruction following → human feedback → conversational products → multimodality → reasoning systems → tool use → agents → long-running work environments.

For creators, this history is itself a content opportunity. Each transition answers a different question: Why did AI become conversational? Why did reasoning models appear? Why did agents become necessary? Why does AI now need tools instead of only text generation?

## 03 — THE EVOLUTION: GPT-1 TO GPT-6 ASTRA

The model names are useful as milestones, but they should not be treated as a simple ladder where every new name replaces everything before it. Different models and product surfaces can serve different purposes.

| ERA               | WHAT CHANGED                                         | WHY IT MATTERED                                                             |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| GPT-1             | Generative pretraining research                      | Established the core paradigm.                                              |
| GPT-2             | Much larger language model                           | Demonstrated stronger coherent generation.                                  |
| GPT-3             | Large-scale few-shot capability                      | One model could perform many tasks from prompts.                            |
| GPT-3.5 / ChatGPT | Instruction following + conversational UX            | AI became accessible to ordinary users at enormous scale.                   |
| GPT-4             | Stronger reasoning and multimodal input              | More capable professional and technical assistance.                         |
| GPT-4o            | Omnimodal interaction                                | Text, vision and audio moved toward a unified experience.                   |
| o1 family         | More inference-time reasoning                        | Harder math, science and coding benefited from deeper reasoning.            |
| GPT-5             | Unified fast + reasoning experience                  | A major step toward model routing and agentic use.                          |
| GPT-5.4–5.6       | Professional work, coding and tools                  | AI increasingly operated as a work assistant.                               |
| GPT-6 Astra       | Computer use, browsing, coding and professional work | The frontier moved further toward AI participating in multi-step workflows. |

A crucial naming distinction: GPT-6 Astra is the model name. ChatGPT is the product that can expose models, tools, context and workflows.

## FROM CHATBOT → ASSISTANT → AGENT → WORK SYSTEM

- Chatbot: answers questions and generates content.
- Assistant: uses files, context and tools to help with a task.
- Agent: plans and executes multi-step actions with tools.
- Work system: stays on a larger objective, coordinates subtasks, uses connected resources and produces finished deliverables.

The practical lesson is that the unit of value is shifting from a single answer to a completed outcome.

## 04 — CHATGPT CAPABILITY MAP

| CAPABILITY               | USE IT FOR                                                                    |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Conversation & reasoning | Explanation, planning, brainstorming, critique, decision support.             |
| Web search               | Current facts, prices, regulations, software changes, news and research.      |
| Deep research            | Multi-source investigations, evidence synthesis and cited reports.            |
| Files & data             | PDFs, documents, spreadsheets, structured analysis and extraction.            |
| Images & vision          | Image understanding, diagrams, screenshots, visual inspection and generation. |
| Voice                    | Hands-free conversation, learning, ideation and real-time interaction.        |
| Coding                   | Debugging, architecture, tests, scripts, refactoring and software projects.   |
| Apps / connected sources | Bring approved external data and, where supported, actions into workflows.    |
| Projects / memory        | Maintain context across ongoing work when enabled.                            |
| Work                     | Long-running, multi-step tasks that produce finished artifacts.               |

## 05 — CODEX: TURNING NATURAL LANGUAGE INTO SOFTWARE WORK

Codex is best understood not as “autocomplete for programmers,” but as an increasingly agentic software-engineering environment. OpenAI launched Codex in 2025 and later introduced the Codex app as a command center for managing multiple agents and long-running coding tasks.

- Understand an unfamiliar repository and explain its architecture.
- Implement a feature across multiple files.
- Debug failing tests and propose the smallest safe fix.
- Write unit, integration and regression tests.
- Refactor legacy code while preserving behavior.
- Review a pull request for correctness, security and maintainability.
- Build a prototype from a product specification.
- Run parallel workstreams for independent engineering tasks.
- Iterate on a frontend using browser feedback and screenshots.

A strong coding instruction contains five parts: repository context → objective → constraints → acceptance tests → definition of done.

## 06 — CHATGPT WORK: FROM PROMPT TO FINISHED DELIVERABLE

ChatGPT Work is designed for more ambitious tasks. It can gather information across apps and workflows, work with files, break complex goals into smaller steps and produce finished materials such as spreadsheets, slides, documents and sites.

Think of Work as the bridge between “tell me how” and “do the work with me.”

- Business: review sales files and produce a management-ready pipeline report.
- Marketing: research competitors, create a positioning matrix and draft launch assets.
- Operations: combine SOPs, identify contradictions and create a revised operating manual.
- Engineering: review design documents, extract requirements, identify risks and create an implementation tracker.

## 07 — DEEP RESEARCH: YOUR RESEARCH ANALYST MODE

Deep research is an agentic capability for complex internet research. It can find, analyze and synthesize large numbers of online sources into comprehensive, cited reports. Current documentation describes deep research across Chat, Work and Codex where available.

### BEST USE CASES

- Market and competitor research
- Academic literature reviews
- Policy and regulatory comparisons
- Technology landscape studies
- Product comparisons
- Historical investigations
- Technical due diligence
- Industry trend analysis
- Evidence gathering for content

### RESEARCH PROMPT PATTERN

Research [QUESTION]. Goal: [DECISION/OUTPUT]. Scope: [DATE RANGE + GEOGRAPHY]. Prioritize primary sources, official documentation, peer-reviewed research and reputable reporting. Compare conflicting evidence. Separate facts, interpretations and assumptions. For every important conclusion, provide supporting sources. End with: executive summary, evidence table, disagreements, limitations, implications and recommended next steps.

## 08 — FILES, DATA AND SOURCE-GROUNDED WORK

When you provide the actual source material, ChatGPT can move from generic advice to context-aware analysis. Useful inputs include PDFs, reports, spreadsheets, presentations, images, notes, codebases and other supported files.

- Extract facts, tables and requirements from documents.
- Compare multiple files and identify contradictions.
- Analyze datasets and explain patterns or anomalies.
- Turn raw material into reports, presentations or action plans.
- Ask for citations, assumptions and validation checks when accuracy matters.

## 09 — 10 UNDERUSED FEATURES / WORKING HABITS

- Give ChatGPT the actual files instead of describing them from memory.
- Ask it to challenge your assumptions, not only agree with you.
- Use explicit acceptance criteria for deliverables.
- Ask for a gap matrix before starting a career or project plan.
- Separate research from interpretation and recommendation.
- Tell it which sources are authoritative for the task.
- Ask for failure cases and edge cases in technical work.
- Use Projects to preserve recurring context and instructions.
- Use structured output when the result will be reused elsewhere.

- Ask for a verification checklist before finalizing important work.

## 10 — CREATOR USE: TURN CHATGPT INTO A CONTENT ENGINE

A creator can use ChatGPT for topic discovery, research, scripting, hooks, repurposing, captions, thumbnail concepts, content calendars, audience analysis and experimentation. The strongest approach is a repeatable system rather than isolated prompts.

Example workflow: audience problem → research → angle selection → hook → script → visual plan → caption → publishing → performance review → next iteration.

A useful prompt asks for multiple hypotheses, explains why each might work, labels assumptions and defines what metric would validate the idea.

### THE CORE WORKFLOW

Define the outcome → provide context → choose tools → specify constraints → set acceptance criteria → execute → verify → revise → package the final result.

That is the central idea of modern ChatGPT: the biggest gains come not from asking more questions, but from designing better workflows.